

MERIDIAN TALENT PARTNERS OOD

Previous AI & Digital Initiative Review

Prepared by Operations Director | April 2026 | Internal

Purpose of This Document

This document summarises all AI, automation, and significant digital transformation initiatives Meridian has undertaken or evaluated since 2021. It was prepared for the AI Value Blueprint engagement to provide honest context on what was tried, what worked, what did not, and what was learned. Prepared by the Operations Director with input from the CEO, both Senior Partners, and the Head of BD.

Initiative 1: LinkedIn Recruiter AI Features (2023–Ongoing)

Status: ONGOING — Limited Value

Department:	Delivery (all teams)
Investment:	€38,400/year (included in LinkedIn Recruiter seat cost; no incremental spend)
Intent:	Use LinkedIn's built-in AI recommendations (Recommended Matches, Smart Suggestions) to accelerate candidate sourcing and reduce manual Boolean search time.
Outcome:	The AI recommendation features are used by most researchers but are consistently rated unreliable for specialist or niche roles. For high-volume generalist roles the suggestions are adequate. For technology roles requiring specific skills (e.g., Rust developer with Kubernetes experience, SAP FICO consultant) or senior executive profiles, the AI surfaces keyword-adjacent candidates who are not genuinely relevant. Researchers continue using Boolean search as primary method, treating LinkedIn AI as a secondary check.

Key lessons learned:

- AI sourcing tools trained on broad platform data work well for common roles and poorly for specialist roles — exactly where Meridian needs the most help.
- Researchers adopted the feature because it required no workflow change, but it did not meaningfully reduce the 6–8 hour sourcing bottleneck.
- The core sourcing problem remains unsolved by LinkedIn's native AI features.

Initiative 2: Lusha Contact Enrichment Trial (Jan–Jun 2023)

Status: ABANDONED

Department:	Delivery (Technology & Engineering team)
Investment:	€1,800 (6-month trial; 5 researcher licences); not renewed
Intent:	Use Lusha's contact enrichment API to automatically add direct phone numbers and emails to LinkedIn-sourced candidate profiles, reducing manual contact research time.

Outcome:	Data quality for Bulgarian, Romanian, and Polish candidates was significantly below marketed levels. Phone number accuracy was approximately 40% for CEE candidates (vs. 70%+ claimed for Western European profiles). The team spent as much time verifying incorrect numbers as finding them manually. Trial abandoned at licence renewal. Key learning: CEE market data quality is a recurring challenge for tools predominantly trained on US/UK profiles.
-----------------	---

Key lessons learned:

- Contact enrichment tools are predominantly US/UK-trained. Data quality degrades significantly in CEE markets — a pattern likely to affect other AI tools evaluated.
- Vendor demo data is typically best-case. Always run a CEE-specific pilot sample before committing to a licence.
- The sourcing bottleneck is not contact data — it is identifying and qualifying relevant candidates in the first place.

Initiative 3: Candidate Database Cleaning Project (2023)

Status: **PARTIALLY COMPLETED — NOT SUSTAINED**

Department:	Operations / Research team
Investment:	€4,800 (freelancer, 3 months) + ~40 hours internal Operations time
Intent:	Clean approximately 47,000 candidate records in Zoho Recruit: remove duplicates, update contact details, and add missing skills tags to improve database search utility.
Outcome:	Approximately 8,000 records were cleaned before budget ran out. No governance process was put in place to maintain data quality. Within 6 months, newly added records reverted to the same quality pattern. The remaining ~39,000 records were never addressed. The Vincere migration is now proceeding without a systematic data cleansing stage, which the Operations Director considers a significant risk to any AI initiative that relies on the candidate database.

Key lessons learned:

- Data cleaning without governance is pointless — you solve the symptom without the cause. The database degrades again immediately.
- The fundamental problem is that researchers have no incentive to maintain candidate records; the benefit (future searchability) accrues to someone else.
- The Vincere migration is an opportunity to enforce data quality from day one — but only if governance is established before migration completes, not after.

Initiative 4: Client Reporting Standardisation Attempt (2024)

Status: **FAILED — REVERTED**

Department:	Delivery (all teams)
Investment:	~8 hours (template design + CEO memo). No tool or system cost.
Intent:	Create a standard weekly client update email template to improve communication consistency and client satisfaction scores on transparency.
Outcome:	A Word template was created by the Operations Director and distributed with a CEO memo in February 2024. Adoption lasted approximately 6 weeks. Senior consultants felt the template was "too formal" and "not suitable for all clients." By April 2024 all consultants had reverted to ad hoc formats. The Q1 2026 satisfaction survey shows "Communication and transparency" still scored lowest at 3.1/5 — unchanged after two years.

Key lessons learned:

- Process changes that rely purely on goodwill and a memo fail. If the behaviour is not enforced by the tool or tracked automatically, it reverts.

- Senior consultants need to see a direct personal benefit to change communication habits — company benefit alone is insufficient motivation.
- The real solution is automated status updates from the ATS, not manually-composed template emails. This requires the ATS to be properly populated first.

Initiative 5: Virtual Assistant for CV Formatting (Apr–Jun 2025)

Status: DISCONTINUED

Department:	Delivery (Technology & Engineering team pilot)
Investment:	€4,200 (3 months VA cost at €1,400/month) + ~15 hours pilot management time
Intent:	Engage a remote virtual assistant to handle CV reformatting to the Meridian template, freeing consultant time for higher-value activities.
Outcome:	A VA was engaged for 3 months via an online platform. Initial quality was inconsistent — approximately 20% of CVs required correction on first attempt. Communication overhead (briefing, reviewing, requesting corrections) consumed 30–45 minutes per CV, compared to 45–60 minutes for the consultant to do it directly. The time saving was marginal. Quality concerns led to discontinuation after 3 months. Consultants reverted to self-formatting.

Key lessons learned:

- Offshoring low-context formatting tasks requires a stable detailed brief and quality checking process — neither was invested in sufficiently.
- The right answer for CV formatting is likely an AI tool that applies formatting rules automatically, not a human VA. The process is too variable and quality-sensitive for a VA without significant briefing overhead.
- The consultants most resistant to the VA were those who cared most about submission quality — a signal worth noting when evaluating any AI formatting tool.

Initiative 6: Informal ChatGPT Adoption (2024–Ongoing)

Status: ONGOING — Unmanaged

Department:	Delivery + BD (individual consultants)
Investment:	~€600/year estimated (individual ChatGPT Plus subscriptions; most may be on free tier)
Intent:	No formal intent — organic adoption by individual consultants using personal ChatGPT accounts for productivity tasks.
Outcome:	Estimated 6–8 consultants use ChatGPT regularly for: writing job descriptions (saves ~30 minutes per JD), drafting candidate summary paragraphs (~20 minutes saved per candidate), writing follow-up emails. There is no company policy, no shared prompt library, and no quality oversight. One client commented informally that a candidate summary "sounded like it was written by a robot." Critically: candidate personal data is being passed into personal ChatGPT accounts, which is a GDPR compliance risk that has not been formally assessed or addressed.

Key lessons learned:

- There is genuine productivity value in AI writing tools — the organic adoption proves the appetite exists without any company push.
- Ungoverned AI use creates quality risk and potential GDPR violations that need to be addressed before scaling up AI use across the firm.
- We need a company-level AI tool policy and a standard prompt library. The informal adoption is a proof point, not a solution.

Summary: What We Know Going Into the Blueprint

Dimension	Assessment
AI sourcing tools	Tried LinkedIn AI and Lusha. Neither solved the specialist sourcing bottleneck. The right tool has not been found. CEE data quality is a recurring challenge for third-party tools.
Data foundation	47,000 candidate records but ~35% poor quality. Vincere migration is an opportunity to reset — but only if governance is established before the migration completes.
Automation of admin tasks	Tried VA for CV formatting (failed) and Word template for reporting (failed). Both were process/governance failures, not technology failures. AI tools may solve what human offshoring could not.
AI writing tools	Organic ChatGPT adoption by 6–8 consultants proves genuine appetite. Needs governance, standardisation, a company account, and a shared prompt library before scaling.
Culture readiness	Leadership is open. Senior consultants are sceptical of AI threatening their value. Junior staff would welcome admin automation. Change management is required for senior-level adoption.
GDPR readiness for AI	Currently insufficient. Candidate data flowing into personal ChatGPT accounts is a live compliance risk. Formal data governance and consent audit needed before scaling any AI use.